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Fixing the Funeral (Canceled)

The best new funeral product in a generation. Kinwood makes short films to celebrate lives. Played at Celebration of Life events



Kinwood, The Celebration...
2 created • 3 backed

More

\$3,400 
pledged of \$9,885 goal

15
backers

 Product Design

 Toronto, Canada

Funding Canceled

Funding for this project was canceled by the project creator on Jun 20 2025

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Story

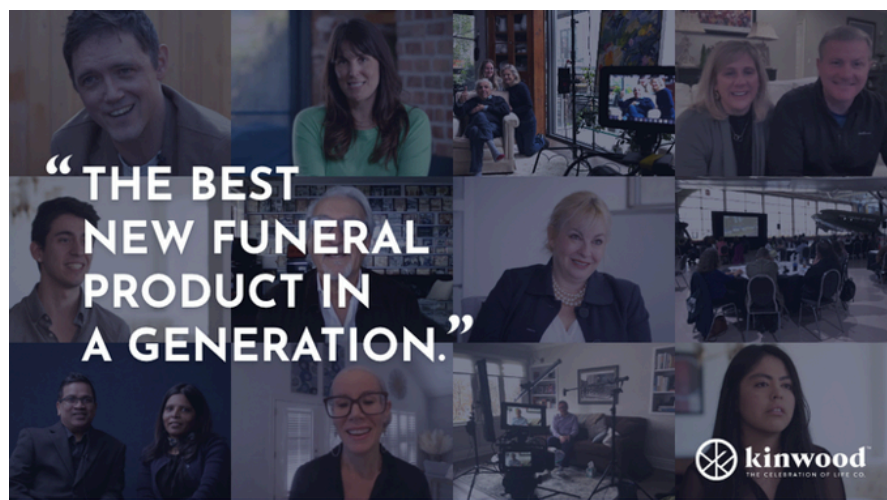
The New Funeral Product

Today, a large majority of North Americans are choosing cremation over a burial. Funeral companies will sell you caskets, cemetery plots, headstones, and markers to support a burial. Families who choose cremation have few options on how they commemorate a life

Kinwood makes short films to celebrate lives. The client family provides photos, cell phone video and 4-8 names for a Kinwood interview. Then our film editors take the interview footage, photos, home movies, cell phone video and produce a beautiful 20-30-minute commemorative film that will remain in the family forever.

These films are often played at a Celebration of Life. Some families that are separated by great distances choose to make a Kinwood film instead of a funeral.

Kinwood understands that families and friends want to "do something" to honor a life. This is it. Part family history, part commemoration, a Kinwood Commemorative Film becomes an instant heirloom and a centerpiece for any Celebration of Life.



Do we really need new funeral options?

Funding period

May 22 2025 - Jul 4 2025 (43 days)

Yes. Today, the cremation rate in the USA is 60% - In the 1960's, it was 5%. Since then, funeral companies have wanted to sell you elaborate funerals – big ones with limousines, fancy caskets, and majestic ceremonies at a church or funeral home.

Attitudes and values around death-care and end-of-life issues are rapidly changing. Many families now walk into a funeral home, ask for a cremation, and tell the funeral director, "We are just going to take the urn and go and do our own thing" – typically at a club, park, restaurant, or a special location like a boxing gym. Kinwood films are for families who are questioning the traditional funeral business.

The Funeral: The product that never improves

Many funeral homes say they are long-time local businesses, but in fact, 25% of them are now owned and controlled by private equity and conglomerates. Private equity has a track-record of investing in industries to increase profits at the expense of customer service levels. Families are leaving the category because they believe that big-funeral companies care most about upselling services that people don't want or need.

So, why haven't funeral companies come up with new and better products? Well, the industry is frozen as private equity, and conglomerates are preoccupied with buying independent funeral homes. Many independent funeral homes are preoccupied with being acquired. No-one is trying to make this better. So unless you want a big traditional funeral with all the trimmings, families have few meaningful options.

You can help Kinwood Films lead the change for more meaningful commemorations and change the entire funeral industry for the better.

Preserving the stories of a life

Whether you watch a Kinwood Commemorative Film on a big screen or re-watch it again on your phone, the stories, sentiment, and feelings of deep connection can be preserved. Many of our films are re-watched dozens of times – and often become the go-to option when you need to go back in time and relive these memories.

Our Journey / The Jody Project

Our founding story: After attending a rash of funerals, a serious question: Is this REALLY? - the best we can do??? Bad carpet, crappy slide shows, and clergy who's never met the deceased.

After a few weeks of looking at the funeral industry, my enthusiasm for the subject grew. I thought there was an opportunity for a new funeral company that was about celebrating lives with modern products and services. After 3-months of kicking it around, I came to my senses and deemed it foolish to quit my marketing career and start a company. I shelved the idea.

About 12 weeks later, one of my closest friends, Jody, 44, was diagnosed with pancreatic cancer and died in just 6 weeks. Total shock. Family and friends devastated. For his celebration of life, my friend Jesse set up a camera at the back of the pub and he did short interviews with friends, asking about their experiences and reflections with Jody. Everyone wanted to share their memories and Jesse ran the camera for 3 hours.

We then got photo albums from his mom, and Jody's friends sent cell-phone pics and videos. Gerrit cut the whole thing and that was our pilot film.

We got our first job through an obituary cold call, and eventually, several more trickled in. We worked with a couple of funeral homes who loved our work, and they made some referrals.

Then, by accident, our MAJOR breakthrough happened. Instead of shooting interviews in person with nice cameras and lenses, a client insisted we use video conferencing. With some new tricks (thanks Gerrit!) we did 10 remote interviews and the film was still amazing! We have completed several more cloud films – (thanks Mel!).

These films are beloved by families – and become an important heirloom. Like the coolest obituary around.

That should get you up to speed.

The Kinwood Team

Our original business idea was to apply the skills of professional creatives to the very un-creative funeral industry. Today, Kinwood is a small team of creative and advertising professionals - who mostly live in different cities. This is us.



Use of Kickstarter Proceeds

So why are we engaging with Kickstarter Backers?

To bring these cloud films to bereaved families, Kinwood needs to build a digital platform so that family and friends can learn, share, and collaborate to make a Kinwood Commemorative Film. Our current website is functionless.

Specifically, your funds will be used to pay for a software engineer to build a new digital platform so families can upload content, invite friends to interviews, and we'll create a cool space where you can watch amazing human stories.

By backing this campaign, Kinwood will deliver the ability for anyone, anywhere, to collaborate with friends and family to make an heirloom that will last forever.



Leave memories, not condolences

Kinwood wants to change how we talk about death that goes beyond 'sorry for your loss.' Leave memories, not condolences, is not just a tagline – it's Kinwood's philosophy. When speaking to somebody in grief, say something specific about the person and how they affected your life. Or just ask them a few questions! What was your mom like when she was in her 20's? What made her laugh out loud?

Kinwood's mission is to produce authentic products for families to celebrate lives. With your support, Kinwood can chart a new path for bereaved families and turn platitudes into amazing life stories.

We can use your help.

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Risks and challenges

Risks and challenges

Kinwood's team has years of professional experience in production and creative delivery – and we know how to make these amazing films. We are planning to hire a skilled software engineer – or two - and hopefully bring them in-house to Kinwood.

As with any tech-build project, we recognize the potential for challenges during the construction of this digital platform. Our commitment is to have outside advisors review our technical plans, to minimize any unforeseen risks. This is Kinwood's first Kickstarter campaign and we are committed to developing the best possible experience for bereaved families.

Our pledge is to keep our backer community updated on our progress and be transparent if challenges develop.

To be honest – we are not sure what kind of reaction this will get.... Our biggest risk might be meeting the demand this new service will generate. With your support I guess we're all going to find out...

[Learn about accountability on Kickstarter](#)

Environmental commitments

[Visit our Environmental Resources Center](#) to learn how Kickstarter encourages sustainable practices.

Long-lasting design

We are replacing caskets with commemorative films!

Reusability and recyclability

Unlike funeral products that will be made from wood and limestone, and then mounted or buried in green spaces, Kinwood films last forever! (and we don't bury anything.)

Questions about this project? [Check out the FAQ](#)

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